Prosperity also unfolded at a differential pace, both between and within these sub-regions. Till recently, they did not perceive an overarching scenario that required a shared response. To the extent that when they needed an agreed meeting point, it was provided by ASEAN-driven platforms. Most importantly, the deep underpinning to the larger stability provided by a pervasive presence of American power has helped to keep the theatre steady till now. It is the revisiting of many of these assumptions and attitudes now that has started to shape the emergence of the Indo-Pacific.

To begin with, there is the reality of the repositioning of the US. Some of it may be reflected in its changed resources and commitments, but there is also the relative growth of competitors and the increasing complexity of challenges. Both the landscape and the tasking demand a response that cannot be the same as before. Call it ‘America First’ or a foreign policy for the middle class, there is widespread recognition of a new era. Where the differences lie within the US are in respect of the vision, attitude and strategy. These are not just divergent but very consequential in their impact on the rest of the world.

The US is undeniably the premier power of our times and will remain so. Indeed, such is its centrality to the current order that be it an ally, a competitor, the agnostic or the undecided, none of us can really be indifferent to its posture. There are different ways by which the US is coming to terms with its constraints and its challenges. And, as we have all seen since 2008, that has not exactly followed a predictable path. Some of the US’s answers lie in reprioritizing; some in a more mobile and affordable footprint; and some perhaps in more tools of influence. Building a technology and financial edge has long worked for it and maintaining that against stiffer competition will be another national response. Where the US, as an entrenched power, is understandably struggling is in respect of new manifestations of exerting influence and wielding power. As an open society, it is not easy to deal with rivals with command polities. It not only has inherent vulnerabilities but also structural constraints while practising these contemporary forms of competition.

But what is important to recognize is that in its own unique way, the American polity is going through a serious introspection. That could well result in a different method of engaging the world. Among its policy changes are a greater emphasis on burden sharing and openness to partners